

Artifact: Safety & First Aid for National Park Families



National Parks are not theme parks. They are vast, unpredictable, and wild landscapes. While they offer some of the most incredible experiences a family can share, they also demand a level of respect and preparation that goes beyond a typical vacation.

When you are miles from the nearest trailhead or cell service, your primary safety resource is the gear in your pack and the knowledge in your head. For families, the stakes are higher. Children get dehydrated faster, lose heat quicker, and are less aware of environmental hazards like steep drop-offs or wildlife boundaries.

This guide is designed as a "Valuable Artifact": a checklist and protocol manual you can save and use every time you head into the backcountry. Our goal is to move you from "worried" to "prepared," ensuring that if a minor scrape or a major weather shift happens, you have a plan ready to go.

The 'Family 15' First Aid Kit (Essentials Only)

Most pre-packaged first aid kits are either too bulky or filled with "filler" items you'll never use. For National Park hiking, you need a kit that focuses on common trail injuries: blisters, scrapes, stings, and minor allergic reactions.

Here are the 15 essentials every family kit must have:

1. **Assorted Adhesive Bandages:** Include "knuckle" shapes and large patches.
2. **Sterile Gauze Pads (3x3):** For larger scrapes that a standard bandage won't cover.
3. **Medical Tape:** To secure gauze or reinforce a bandage on a moving joint.
4. **Antiseptic Wipes:** Alcohol-free is better for kids as it doesn't sting as much.
5. **Triple Antibiotic Ointment:** To prevent infection on the go.
6. **Tweezers:** Essential for removing splinters, thorns, or ticks.
7. **Small Scissors:** For cutting tape, moleskin, or clothing in an emergency.
8. **Disposable Gloves:** At least two pairs to maintain hygiene during treatment.
9. **Hydrocortisone Cream:** For relief from itchy bug bites or plant rashes (poison ivy/oak).
10. **Children's Ibuprofen or Acetaminophen:** For fevers or pain management.
11. **Antihistamine (Liquid or Chewable):** Crucial for unexpected allergic reactions to plants or insects.
12. **Moleskin or Blister Pads:** Don't wait for the blister to pop; apply at the first sign of a "hot spot."
13. **Oral Rehydration Salts:** Small packets that can be mixed into water to treat severe dehydration.
14. **Instant Cold Pack:** For sprains or heat-related discomfort.
15. **Digital Thermometer:** To monitor for fever or signs of heatstroke.



Pro Tip: Store these in a bright-colored, waterproof dry bag. If you need to tell a child to "go get the first aid kit," it needs to be easy to spot and bone-dry.

Wildlife Safety Protocols (Bears, Elk, Bison)

Seeing a bear or a bison is often the highlight of a trip, but it is also the most common point of injury. Families often make the mistake of treating wildlife like statues or pets.

The Rule of Thumb

Teach your children the "Rule of Thumb." Hold your arm out straight and put your thumb up. If you can't completely cover the animal with your thumb, you are too close.

Bison and Elk

In parks like Yellowstone or Rocky Mountain, these animals are everywhere. Bison may look slow, but they can outrun a human easily and are notoriously temperamental.

- **Protocol:** Stay at least 25 yards (two bus lengths) away. If an animal stops what it's doing and looks at you, you are already too close. Back away slowly.

Bear Safety

In "Bear Country" (Grand Teton, Glacier, Great Smoky Mountains), noise is your best friend.

- **Protocol:** Talk loudly, sing songs, or clap your hands, especially near running water or thick brush. This prevents you from "surprising" a bear.
- **Bear Spray:** Carry it in a holster on your belt or chest strap, NOT inside your pack. You should be able to deploy it in less than two seconds. Ensure older teens know how to use it, and keep it out of reach of small children.

Lost-Child Protocol (Whistles, Colors, Check-points)

The nightmare of every parent is losing sight of a child on a crowded or winding trail. Prevention is key, but having a "Lost Protocol" reduces panic if separation occurs.

The Morning Photo

Every morning before you leave the car or hotel, take a photo of your children on your phone. This gives search and rescue an exact image of what they are wearing that day.

High-Visibility Clothing

Avoid dressing kids in "earth tones" (greens, browns, or greys). Choose "safety" colors: neon orange, bright pink, or electric blue. These colors stand out against forest and rock backgrounds, making it easier for you (and rescuers) to spot them.

The Safety Whistle

Every person in the family, including children as young as three, should have a safety whistle attached to their zipper or pack.

- **The Rule:** Three sharp blasts means "I am lost" or "I need help."

- **Training:** Teach your kids that the whistle is a tool, not a toy. They should only blow it if they cannot see an adult from their group.

S.T.O.P.

If a child realizes they are lost, teach them the S.T.O.P. acronym:

- **S - Sit down:** Moving around makes it harder for people to find you.
- **T - Think:** Stay calm. Remember your training.
- **O - Observe:** Look around. Can you see the trail? Is there a safe spot to sit?
- **P - Plan:** Blow your whistle and wait for help.



Hydration & Sun Exposure Logic

Many families underestimate how quickly the environment saps moisture from the body, especially at high altitudes where the air is dry.

The Hydration Math

A general rule for hiking is half a liter of water per hour for an adult in moderate conditions. For children, aim for 1-2 cups every hour.

- **The "Pee Test":** If your child hasn't needed to use the bathroom in several hours, or if their urine is dark yellow, they are already dehydrated.
- **Electrolytes:** Water alone isn't always enough if you are sweating. Bring salty snacks (pretzels) or electrolyte tabs to maintain salt balance.

Sun Logic

In high-altitude parks like Bryce Canyon or Zion, the sun is significantly more intense.

- **The 2-Hour Rule:** Reapply sunscreen every two hours, even if it says "all day."
- **Physical Blocks:** Hats and UPF-rated clothing are superior to cream because they don't sweat off. Make sure kids wear wide-brimmed hats that protect the back of the neck.

The 'Before-You-Leave' Health Scan

Before you pull out of the parking lot and head onto the trail, perform a 60-second "Health Scan" for the whole family. This prevents you from being two miles in when a problem surfaces.

1. **The Foot Check:** Are shoes tied correctly? Are socks pulled up to prevent heel rubbing?
2. **The Water Check:** Does everyone have their own water source? Is it full?
3. **The Layer Check:** Do we have rain shells in the pack? (Weather changes in minutes in the mountains).
4. **The "Ranger" Check:** Have we checked the trailhead board for recent alerts, trail closures, or weather warnings?
5. **The Mental Check:** Is everyone feeling okay? If a child is already grumpy or tired at the car, a 5-mile loop is a bad idea. Pivot to a shorter 1-mile overlook trail.



Final Thought

Safety in our National Parks isn't about being afraid; it's about being competent. When you have the 'Family 15' in your pack and your kids know the S.T.O.P. protocol, you clear the mental space to actually enjoy the scenery.

Respect the landscape, keep your distance from the wildlife, and always carry more water than you think you need.

Save this checklist for your next trip to ensure your family stays safe on the trail.